

CHAPTER 3

BASIC PARAGRAPH STRUCTURE

ANALYZING THE MODEL

The writing model discusses the advantages of leisure time.

Read the model. Then answer the questions.



Writing Model

Take a Break!

1 In today's busy world, it is easy to forget about the importance of taking time off. 2 Whether it lasts for a couple of hours or a few days, leisure time has specific benefits. 3 First of all, relaxation reduces stress that can lead to serious health problems. 4 For example, some people spend a restful day watching movies or reading. 5 Others play sports. 6 Whatever the activity, they begin to feel physically and emotionally stronger. 7 The next benefit is creativity. 8 Individuals with hobbies such as photography, travel, and music develop new talents and get ideas that they can use at school or in the office. 9 Finally, interests outside of work can lead to a positive attitude. 10 For instance, when volunteers help children learn to read, they feel wonderful about what they have achieved. 11 Then they feel like working harder when they return to their regular responsibilities. 12 All in all, leisure time helps people stay healthy and has the additional benefit of allowing them to work more industriously and productively.

Questions about the Model

1. Look at the title. What is the topic of the paragraph?
2. Look at the second sentence. What does it say about the topic?
3. Now look at the last sentence. Does it summarize the main points or restate the topic sentence in different words?

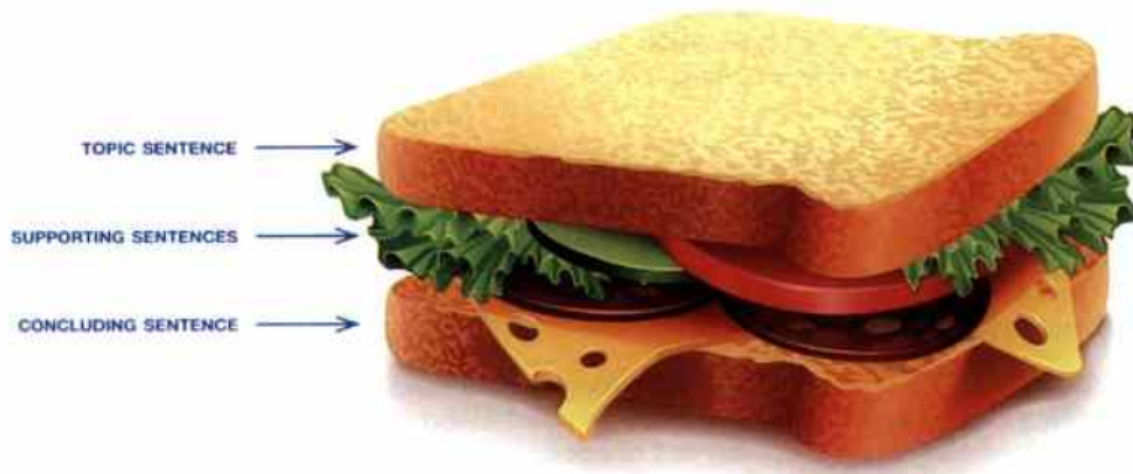
PRACTICE 7

Identifying Main Points and Examples

Reread the writing model on page 52. Find two more main points and three more examples. Copy them into the appropriate boxes on the diagram.

ORGANIZATION

A paragraph is like a sandwich. The topic sentence and concluding sentence are the two pieces of “bread” enclosing the “meat”—the supporting sentences.



The topic sentence presents the main idea of the paragraph. The supporting sentences give information to explain or prove the main idea. The concluding sentence summarizes the main idea or restates the topic sentence in different words.

THE TOPIC SENTENCE

The topic sentence is the most important sentence in a paragraph. It has two parts: a **topic** and a **controlling idea**. The topic names the subject of the paragraph. In the writing model on page 52, the topic is *leisure time*. The controlling idea tells the main idea about the topic. It is called the controlling idea because it controls, or limits, the topic to a very specific idea. In the model, the controlling idea is that leisure time is beneficial.

Here are examples of topic sentences with the same topic but different controlling ideas:

- 1a. TOPIC CONTROLLING IDEA
Some hobbies are relaxing.
- 1b. TOPIC CONTROLLING IDEA
Some hobbies are too expensive.
- 2a. TOPIC CONTROLLING IDEA
Some jobs are dangerous.
- 2b. TOPIC CONTROLLING IDEA
Some jobs are repetitive and boring.
- 2c. TOPIC CONTROLLING IDEA
Some jobs are perfect for students.

Position of the Topic Sentence

The topic sentence is usually the first or second sentence in a paragraph. Experienced writers sometimes put topic sentences at the end, but the best place is usually at the beginning. A topic sentence at the beginning of a paragraph gives readers an idea of what they will be reading. This helps them understand the paragraph more easily.

Not Too General, Not Too Specific

A topic sentence is neither too general nor too specific.

TOO GENERAL A job is part of life.

This is too general because there is no specific controlling idea. The reader has no idea what the paragraph will say about jobs except that people have them.

TOO SPECIFIC An increasing number of people in the United States work 50 hours a week.

This is too specific. It gives a detail that should come later in the paragraph.

GOOD The number of hours that Americans work each week has changed in the past 30 years.

This is a good topic sentence because it gives the reader a hint that the paragraph will discuss changes to the number of hours that Americans work. A good topic sentence tells something about the contents of the paragraph but does not give the details.

PRACTICE 3 Identifying Good Topic Sentences

- A** Check (✓) the good topic sentences. What is wrong with the others? Write *Too specific* or *Too general*.

Too specific

- _____ 1. It is estimated that leisure travelers spend more than \$500 billion in the United States.
- ✓ _____ 2. Research shows that there are three main purposes for leisure travel.
- _____ 3. Digital cameras have several advantages over film cameras.
- _____ 4. Digital cameras are a common form of technology these days.
- _____ 5. Digital photos are composed of small squares, just like a tiled kitchen floor or bathroom wall.
- _____ 6. Learning the meanings of the abbreviations used in text messaging is like learning a new language.
- _____ 7. BRB, BTW, CU, and F2F are abbreviations.
- _____ 8. Smart phones can perform a variety of useful functions.
- _____ 9. Consider these four factors when buying your next phone.
- _____ 10. Cats have certain characteristics that make them good family animals.
- _____ 11. Animal shelters take care of homeless dogs and cats.
- _____ 12. It is a good idea to volunteer at an animal shelter.

- B** Read each paragraph. Circle the best topic sentence in the list. Then write it on the line.

PARAGRAPH 1

Mountain Climbing

There are three main types of mountain climbing.

Trail climbing is the easiest. Climbers just walk along trails to the top of a mountain. The trails are not very steep, and the mountains are small. The second type, rock climbing, takes place on steeper slopes and bigger mountains. Climbers generally have to use special equipment such as climbing shoes, ropes, and metal nails called pitons. The third type is ice climbing. Ice climbing takes place only on very high mountains and requires a lot of special equipment. Equipment used in ice climbing includes ice axes and crampons, which are spikes attached to a climber's boots for walking on ice and hard snow. In short, mountain climbing can range from an easy walk to a challenging trek.

- ☒ a. There are three main types of mountain climbing.
- ☐ b. Mountain climbing requires special skills and equipment.
- ☐ c. The sport of mountain climbing is practiced worldwide.
- ☐ d. Mountain climbing is one of the most difficult sports.

PARAGRAPH 2

Regional Foods in the United States

For example, Kansas City, in the very center of the United States, is known for its beef, and Kansas City barbecue is everyone's favorite way to enjoy it. In Boston, people love baked beans. In the Southwest, chili, a stew made of meat, beans, tomatoes, and hot peppers, is the regional dish. Wisconsin, a state with many dairy farms, is famous for its cheese. Go to Maryland and Virginia for egg cakes, which are fried egg and breadcrumb patties. In the Northeast, try fish chowder, a rich fish, potato, and onion soup. Indeed, many U.S. cities and regions have a special food for everyone to enjoy.

- ☐ a. There is a variety of food in the United States.
- ☐ b. Food in the United States varies from sweet desserts to spicy stews.
- ☐ c. Different regions of the United States have their own traditional foods.
- ☐ d. Food in the United States is quite delicious.

PARAGRAPH 3

Why Everyone Should Try Yoga

First, it is easy to get started. Unlike other forms of exercise, yoga does not require a lot of special equipment or clothing, and it can be done almost anywhere.

Next, yoga is a good form of exercise regardless of people's age or physical condition when they start out. However, most important are the benefits of yoga. It improves body strength and flexibility and is an excellent way to relieve stress. It is clear that yoga is an easy-to-do and beneficial way to get exercise.

- a. Yoga is a way to strengthen the body and the mind.
- b. Yoga is becoming popular with people of all ages.
- c. Yoga is an excellent form of exercise for several reasons.
- d. Yoga is an example of how getting exercise reduces stress.

PRACTICE 4

Writing Good Topic Sentences

Read each paragraph. Identify the topic and the controlling idea. Then write an appropriate topic sentence on the line.

PARAGRAPH 1

A World of Flavors

Foods from all over the world are popular in the United States.

Even small towns in the United States have at least one pizzeria and one Chinese restaurant. Every midsize town has at least one taqueria, where you can get a delicious Mexican taco or burrito. French food has always been popular, and hot dogs and hamburgers, German in origin, are found everywhere. More recently, Middle Eastern shish kebab, Japanese sushi, and English fish and chips are increasingly available in the United States. These examples show that American cuisine is actually quite international.

PARAGRAPH 2

Skipping Breakfast

Some people say that they skip breakfast because they think it will help them lose weight. Another reason people give is that they simply don't like breakfast. Others say that the reason is cultural. People in their home culture usually consume only two meals a day, and breakfast isn't traditionally one of them. The most common reason people give is lack of time. They like to stay in bed until the last minute, and then they have to rush to get to work or to school on time. To sum up, there are a variety of explanations for not eating breakfast.

PARAGRAPH 3

Grand Canyon, Grand Vacation

First of all, travelers should decide what time of year they would like to visit the Grand Canyon. It can be very cold in winter, and it sometimes snows throughout the month of May. However, summers are hot, and because the Grand Canyon is a popular tourist destination for families on vacation, it can be very crowded during the summer months. Another thing to think about is where to stay. There are hotels in and near the Grand Canyon, but they are not cheap. Some travelers prefer camping as a way of enjoying nature and saving money. Finally, visitors should consider the various ways to see the canyon. Possibilities include the lookout points along the South Rim, the Skywalk on the West Rim, or a helicopter ride. In conclusion, any trip to the Grand Canyon is sure to be fantastic, and with a little planning it can be even better.

SUPPORTING SENTENCES: MAIN POINTS



After you write a topic sentence, you must provide information to support it. In supporting sentences, you present main points about the topic (for example, reasons, advantages, categories, or events in a narration) and supporting details (examples, facts, description, explanations, and definitions).

Look at these main points from the writing model on page 52. They present three key benefits of leisure time, which are then followed by examples and explanations.

MAIN POINTS

First of all, relaxation reduces stress that can lead to serious health problems.

The next benefit is creativity.

Finally, interests outside of work can lead to a positive attitude.

PRACTICE 5

Writing Main Points

Work with a partner or in a small group. Read each topic sentence and the main point provided. Then add as many main points as you can.

1. Travel by plane has several disadvantages.

- a. Airplane travel is generally expensive.
- b. _____
- c. _____

2. Reading helps English language learners improve their English.

- a. Reading English texts helps learners expand their vocabulary.
- b. _____
- c. _____

3. Consider these important factors when planning a party.

- a. Think about the number of guests you want to invite.
- b. _____
- c. _____

5. Avoid stress when studying for a big test by taking the following actions.

- a. Begin studying days ahead of time.
- b. _____
- c. _____

UNITY IN THE SUPPORTING SENTENCES OF A PARAGRAPH

ELLT

In English, **unity** is an important element of a good academic paragraph. In a paragraph with unity, all the supporting sentences work together to support the topic sentence. Each sentence is directly linked to the topic and the controlling idea about the topic. In some languages, it might be acceptable to wander away from the topic and controlling idea—to make side trips to other ideas that are somewhat, but not directly, related to the topic sentence. In English, doing so is not acceptable because it breaks the unity of a paragraph.

PRACTICE 4 Editing Paragraphs for Unity

Find the sentences that are off topic. Cross out one more sentence in Paragraph 1 and one sentence in Paragraph 2.

PARAGRAPH 1

Secrets of Good Ads

A good ad has three characteristics. First of all, a good ad is simple. It lets pictures, and very few words, tell the story. ~~Television ads are more effective than ads in newspapers and magazines.~~ Second, a good ad targets a particular group of consumers. For example, ads for face creams usually target middle-aged and older women, while ads for motorcycles target young, single men. Third, a good ad appeals to people's emotions. For instance, women in the 30-to-50 age group often want to look and feel younger, so face-cream ads promise them that using a specific product will make them look more youthful. Teenagers, on the other hand, often want to be popular, so ads directed at teens often show a happy, confident-looking group of young people using the products in the ads. Teenagers have a surprising amount of money to spend, so advertisers research teenage fads. In conclusion, a good ad is simple, targets a specific group, and appeals to that group's emotions.

PARAGRAPH 2

Cookies, but Not the Ones to Eat

Internet cookies are small information files that websites put onto personal computers. Online shoppers with worries about cookies should know that the cookies have advantages both for them and for merchants. The main function of cookies is to give Internet users quick access to webpages. For example, because of cookies, customers on ecommerce sites can keep items in their shopping carts while they look at additional products and then check out with ease whenever they are ready. Cookies also allow a website to remember personal information such as a consumer's name, home address, email address, and phone number, so that these items do not have to be reentered. Some people believe that cookies will damage their computers, but this is not true. For online sellers, cookies provide an important advantage. They allow the sellers to collect information about visitors to a website. Merchants can then use this customer data for advertising and other marketing purposes. Although there are concerns about what sellers might do with private information, it is clear that cookies have their benefits.

COHERENCE IN THE SUPPORTING SENTENCES OF A PARAGRAPH

Putting Each Supporting Sentence in the Right Place

One way to make a paragraph more coherent is to put each sentence in the right place. For example, if you are discussing the first reason why you use credit cards, put all of your supporting information for your first main point together. If you are including dates or using time-order signals, be sure that your sentences follow a clear time sequence (1940, 1962, 2001; at first, next, later).

PRACTICE 5 Editing Paragraphs for Coherence

Circle the sentence in each paragraph that is not in a logical position. Draw an arrow to show where the sentence should be placed.

PARAGRAPH 1

A Short History of Smart Phones

Smart phones are a useful combination of communication device, personal organizer, camera, educational tool, and entertainment center. They are a common part of life in the 21st century, but they have a very short history. In the 1990s, there were two kinds of mobile devices: cell phones and PDAs (personal digital assistants). People used their cell phones to make calls and their PDAs to organize their lives by storing information such as their daily schedules and the names, addresses, and phone numbers of their contacts. Then in 2002, the Palm Treo and the Sony Ericsson P800 successfully combined the two types of technology. Treo users could make phone calls and use PDA functions such as sending email, setting up calendars, and editing computer documents. The P800 also included an MP3 player. One year later, in 2003, BlackBerry further developed smart phone technology. When Android phones came on the market in 2008, smart phones became less expensive to buy and even more widely used. In 2007, the iPhone achieved great success, especially because of the variety of apps that were available for it. Since 2008, manufacturers have continued to develop faster, more powerful, and more affordable mobile technology. It will be interesting to see what happens in the future.

Kinds of Salespeople

Watch out for three distinct kinds of salespeople because they will try to trick you into buying products you don't really want. The first type of salesperson is the one who pretends to be your best friend. He shares his personal experience as soon as you tell him what you want to buy. For instance, if you are planning to purchase a pair of running shoes, he shows you his favorite pair of running shoes and describes how fantastic they would look on you. Before you know it, you are buying the most expensive shoes in the store. Beware also of a second type of salesperson, the one who claims to be an "expert." He has all the answers and can give you the best advice on what to buy. Suppose you are buying a television. He will flood you with details about various models until you are so overwhelmed, you cannot compare the various models on your own. The only logical choice is to ask the expert what he recommends, regardless of the cost. Finally, avoid the super-aggressive salesperson who pushes and pushes until you buy. He tells you, for example, that the printer you want is only on sale today or that he has only one left in stock. He insists that you should not leave the store without making a purchase. Like a friend, he asks how you are and listens attentively as you tell him about your life. In conclusion, steer clear of any salesperson who is too friendly, too much of a know-it-all, or too aggressive, unless you want someone else to make your shopping decisions for you.

Using Nouns and Pronouns Consistently

Another way to achieve coherence is to use nouns and pronouns consistently throughout a paragraph. Continue to use the same nouns and pronouns that you start off with. For example, if you begin a paragraph with a plural noun, such as *students*, don't change to the singular *student*. Also, don't change pronouns for no reason. Don't switch from *you* to *they* or *he* unless there is a clear reason to do so. Be consistent! If you use the pronoun *you* at the beginning of your paragraph, keep it throughout.

Notice how nouns and pronouns in the paragraph have been changed to make them consistent.

Different Kinds of Majors

^{Students}
~~A student~~ can choose many possible majors if ~~he or she is~~ ^{they are}
interested in studying business at college. Before choosing a college,
~~he or she~~ ^{they} should look at the types of business majors offered at
different schools. For example, ~~you~~ ^{they} can study business administration,
finance, accounting, or sales and marketing. By reading the
course descriptions, ~~a potential student~~ ^{potential students} can understand how the
majors differ.

PRACTICE 7

Editing a Paragraph for Consistency

Find seven more consistency errors in the use of nouns and pronouns. Make corrections.

Working as a Retail Buyer

Young people who are interested in the latest styles may want to consider working as ~~a buyer~~ ^{buyers} for retail stores. Retail buyers work for department stores and large chain stores. They look for and choose the merchandise to sell in the store. Retail buyers often specialize in one type of merchandise, such as men's casual clothing or women's shoes. You choose the merchandise that you think will sell well in your stores and appeal to your customers. Buyers also travel to trade shows to look at merchandise. He or she will purchase products about six months before the merchandise appears in the stores. You need to be able to predict the latest styles trends, understand retail sales, and work cooperatively with managers in sales, advertising, and marketing.

Placing and Punctuating Transition Signals Correctly

Transition signals are like traffic signals. They tell your reader when to slow down, turn around, and stop. You have already used several transition signals. The chart presents those you know and a few new ones.

SENTENCE CONNECTORS	COORDINATING CONJUNCTIONS	OTHERS
To present main points in time order		
First (second, etc.), First of all, Later, Meanwhile, Next, After that, Now Soon Then Finally,		To begin with,

SENTENCE CONNECTORS	COORDINATING CONJUNCTIONS	OTHERS
To present main points in a logical division of ideas pattern		
First (second, etc.), First of all, Furthermore, Also, In addition, Moreover,	and	A second (reason, kind, advantage, etc.) . . . An additional (reason, kind, advantage, etc.) . . . The final (reason, kind, advantage, etc.) . . .
To add a similar idea		
Similarly, Likewise, Also, Furthermore, In addition, Moreover,	and	
To add an opposite idea		
On the other hand, However,	but	
To give an example		
For example, For instance,		such as (+ noun)
To give a reason		
	for	because of (+ noun)
To give a result		
Therefore, Thus, Consequently, As a result,	so	
To add a conclusion		
All in all, For these reasons, In brief, In conclusion, To summarize, To sum up,		It is clear that . . . You can see that . . . You can see from these examples that . . . These examples show that . . .

Sentence Connectors

These words and phrases often come at the beginning of a sentence. They are usually followed by a comma. (Exceptions: *Now*, *soon*, and *then* do not take a comma.)

BEGINNING OF SENTENCE

First of all, a good ad is simple.

Then Android phones came on the market in 2008.

In conclusion, be aware.

Sentence connectors can also come in the middle and at the end of a sentence. We usually (but not always) separate them from the rest of the sentence with a comma or commas.

MIDDLE OF SENTENCE

Teenagers, **on the other hand**, want to feel popular.

Some jobs can **also** teach useful skills such as basic accounting or database management.

END OF SENTENCE

She will be in debt for years, **as a result**.

They make it possible for students to pay their bills, **for example**.

Coordinating Conjunctions

Use these to combine two simple sentences into a compound sentence. Put a comma after the first simple sentence.

High school students have a surprising amount of money to spend, **so** advertisers research teenage fads and fashions.

Others

These words are adjectives and prepositions. There is no special punctuation rule that applies to all of these words.

One reason to be a vegetarian is that it can increase health.

Another characteristic of a good boss is fairness.

Compound Sentences with Coordinators

A compound sentence can be formed as follows:

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE COORDINATOR INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
Saltwater boils at a lower temperature than freshwater, so food cooks faster in saltwater.

There are seven **coordinators**, which are also called coordinating conjunctions. You can remember them by the phrase *FAN BOYS* (*For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So*). The examples in the chart illustrate the meanings of the seven *FAN BOYS* coordinators. (*Punctuation note: Use a comma after the first independent clause.*)

COORDINATORS (COORDINATING CONJUNCTIONS)		
Coordinator	Meaning / Use	Examples
for	To add a reason	Japanese people live longer than many other nationalities, for they eat healthful diets.
and	To add a similar, equal idea	They eat a lot of fish and vegetables, and they eat lightly.
nor	To add a negative, equal idea	They do not eat a lot of red meat, nor do they eat many dairy products.
but	To add an opposite idea	Diet is one factor in how long people live, but it is not the only factor.
or	To add an alternative possibility	However, people should limit the amount of animal fat in their diets, or they risk getting heart disease.
yet	To add an unexpected or surprising continuation	Cigarette smoking is a factor in longevity, yet some smokers live long lives.
so	To add an expected result	Doctors say that stress is another longevity factor, so try to avoid stress if you wish to live a longer life.

Notes

- *Nor* means “and not.” It joins two negative independent clauses. Notice that question word order is used after *nor*.
- *But* and *yet* have similar meanings: They both signal that an opposite idea is coming. *But* is preferred when the two clauses are direct opposites. When the second clause is an unexpected or surprising continuation because of information given in the first clause, *yet* is preferred. (*But* is acceptable for both meanings; *yet* for only one meaning.) Compare these examples:

I want to study art, **but** my parents want me to study engineering.
(direct opposite)

I am very bad at math, **yet** my parents want me to study engineering.
(surprising continuation after “I am very bad at math”)

PRACTICE 2

Choosing *But* vs. *Yet*

Which coordinator would you use to connect the two clauses in these sentences? Write either *but* or *yet* on the line.

1. a. Too much sun damages the skin, _____ many people still do not use sunscreen.
- b. Too much sun damages the skin, _____ too little sun also causes health problems.
2. a. The company's sales increased last year, _____ its profits declined.
- b. The company moved its marketing division to Phoenix, _____ the operations division stayed in Boston.
3. a. Population growth has slowed in most developing countries, _____ it has not slowed enough to avoid serious problems.
- b. The fertility rate in India has decreased from 6 to 2.58 births per female, _____ India's population is expanding at the rate of 17.5 million per year.

B For each pair of sentences, form a compound sentence by joining the two independent clauses with a coordinator that best fits the meaning. Use each FAN BOYS coordinator once. Write your new sentences on a separate sheet of paper and punctuate them correctly.

1. Nuclear accidents can happen. Nuclear power plants must have strict safety controls.
Nuclear accidents can happen, so nuclear power plants must have strict safety controls.
2. The accidents at nuclear power plants in the United States and the former Soviet Union in the 1980s created fears about the safety of this energy source. The disaster at Fukushima in Japan in 2011 reinforced them.
3. Solar heating systems are economical to operate. The cost of installation is very high.
4. Energy needs are not going to decrease. Energy sources are not going to increase.
(Note: Use nor and question word order in the second clause, deleting the word not).
5. Burning fossil fuels causes serious damage to our planet. We need to develop other sources of energy.
6. Ecologists know that burning fossil fuels causes holes in the ozone layer. People continue to do it.
7. Developed nations especially will continue this harmful practice. They require more energy to fuel cars, air-conditioning, and other modern luxuries.
8. All nations of the world must take action. Our children and grandchildren will suffer the consequences.

Complete the paragraph with the transition signals from the box. Capitalize and punctuate them correctly. Use each signal once.

finally

for example

such as

~~first of all~~

a second strategy

then

Black Friday

In the United States, the Friday after Thanksgiving, also known as Black Friday, is the busiest shopping day of the year. There are several surefire methods that business owners use to get customers into their stores on Black Friday. First of all, ^{1.} merchants offer sale prices on holiday gifts and decorations. ^{2.} is to tell customers that there will be deep discount prices on a few in-demand items. ^{3.} big-screen televisions might be on sale for only \$250, but the number of them actually available is limited. ^{4.} retailers open their doors at 6:00 A.M. or even earlier. They know that bargain shoppers will be waiting at the door ready to buy. ^{5.} store owners use marketing. They put ads in print and online newspapers, or they advertise through other media, ^{6.} radio and television, to create Black Friday shopping excitement.

Using Various Transition Signals for Coherence

Complete the paragraph by choosing the correct transition signal. Capitalize the signals as needed correctly. Use the punctuation to help you select the right answer.

Getting a Parking Space at the Mall

Parking is a major challenge for customers at large shopping malls. Three common sense strategies will go a long way toward meeting the challenge.

_____ ^{1.} *First* (first / therefore / moreover), customers should arrive either early or late. _____ ^{2.} (but / for example / second), if the stores open at 9:30 A.M., customers will find plenty of spaces available in the outdoor parking lots and garages until approximately 10:30. There is still hope for those who are busy in the morning hours, _____ ^{3.} (consequently / furthermore / however). Shoppers who do not have to be at home for dinner will find plenty of places to leave their vehicles as long as they are in the parking area after daytime shoppers leave and before the evening crowd comes. _____ ^{4.} (next / for / for instance), it is important for mall patrons to pay attention to the location of the spot where they park. At popular malls, the hundreds of parking spaces all look the same, _____ ^{5.} (so / also / furthermore) drivers should have a plan of action, _____ ^{6.} (therefore / such as / moreover) writing down their section and row number or taking a photo of their location with a smart phone. Drivers can _____ ^{7.} (also / finally / however) park near an entrance to their favorite store or another easy-to-remember location. _____ ^{8.} (for / finally / so), shoppers should not be afraid to do a little walking. Sometimes, no convenient parking will be available. Instead of driving around for 15 minutes, the best option is to take that faraway space and get down to business. _____ ^{9.} (to sum up / for example / next), the goal is getting out of the car and into the stores with as little frustration as possible.

THE CONCLUDING SENTENCE

The concluding sentence signals the end of a paragraph and reminds the reader of the controlling idea. Here are three tips to help you write a good concluding sentence:

1. Begin with a conclusion signal. Most conclusion signals have commas after them; others do not.

CONCLUSION SIGNALS	EXAMPLES
Followed by a Comma	
All in all,	In short, mountain climbing can range from an easy walk to a challenging trek.
In summary,	Indeed, many U.S. cities and regions have a special food for everyone to enjoy.
In brief,	
To conclude,	
In conclusion,	
To summarize,	
Indeed,	
To sum up,	
In short,	
Not Followed by a Comma	
It is clear that . . .	It is clear that yoga is an easy-to-do, beneficial way to get exercise.
These examples show that . . .	
You can see that . . .	

2. Use one of these methods to remind your reader of the topic sentence.
 - Repeat the controlling idea in the topic sentence in different words. Do not just copy the topic sentence.

TOPIC SENTENCE Some hobbies are too expensive.

CONCLUDING SENTENCE Indeed, most people simply do not have enough money for certain pastimes.

- Summarize the main points of the paragraph.

CONCLUDING SENTENCE In short, only the very wealthiest of people can afford to be serious collectors of coins, old cars, and art.

3. You may give your final thoughts, a suggestion, or a prediction in your conclusion. However, never end a paragraph by introducing a new and unrelated idea!

INCORRECT In conclusion, becoming a collector offers a great deal of enjoyment.

CORRECT In conclusion, consider the cost before beginning a new hobby.

Identifying Effective Concluding Sentences

Read the paragraph. Circle the best concluding sentence in the list. Then write it on the lines. Be prepared to explain your choice to the class.

Getting Involved in Campus Life

Students who participate in activities outside of class receive a number of advantages. To begin with, joining a club or attending a campus event can provide a much-needed break from studying. In addition, getting involved in student activities is a good way to make new friends. This is especially important for students who are feeling alone during their first days at a new school. Another advantage is learning new skills. For example, students who belong to a psychology club can learn more about their major and develop leadership skills that will be valuable later in life. _____



- In conclusion, students can have a lot of fun when they join campus activities.
- In conclusion, students who are involved in campus life get more out of school.
- In conclusion, students will not feel lonely if they join a club with other students.

PRACTICE 9

Writing Effective Concluding Sentences

Write an appropriate concluding sentence for each paragraph. Be sure to begin with a conclusion signal.

PARAGRAPH 1

Smart Choices in the Cafeteria

The college cafeteria is full of food that can cause weight gain, but students have choices. For example, breakfast options include fruit and yogurt instead of pastries or bagels. At lunch, it is possible to have a green salad instead of a burger and fries or a slice of pizza. An excellent dinner choice is baked chicken with vegetables rather than a large serving of spaghetti or macaroni and cheese. _____

PARAGRAPH 2

Children's TV for Language Learning

Watching children's programs on television is a good way to learn a foreign language. In fact, the spread of English has been helped by children's TV. First, the actors speak slowly and repeat often. Also, the vocabulary they use is not difficult. Finally, there is always a lot of action, so you know what is happening even if you don't fully understand the words. _____
